The Long Tail of Software

What 8,782 revenue-verified startups reveal about who actually makes money

43% make $0 — TrustMRR full dataset, frozen July 30, 2026. Stripe and RevenueCat verified revenue.

For Once, the Revenue Is Real

This is a live census of the indie and micro-SaaS economy — revenue verified directly through payment processors, not self-reported.

8,782

Startups

Across 117 countries

$185M

ARR Run-Rate

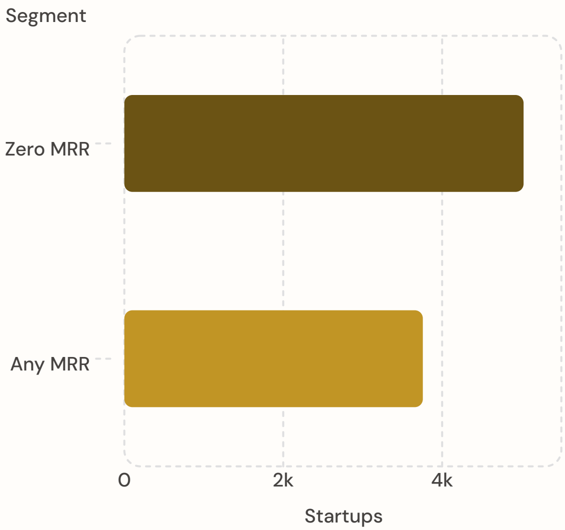
$15.4M aggregate monthly MRR

$1.5B

All-Time Revenue

Cumulative across the marketplace

The Dream and the Distribution Are Not the Same Thing



Median MRR across all 8,782 listings: **$0**. Only 42.8% of startups generate any recurring revenue at all. "Revenue-verified" mostly verifies the *absence* of revenue.

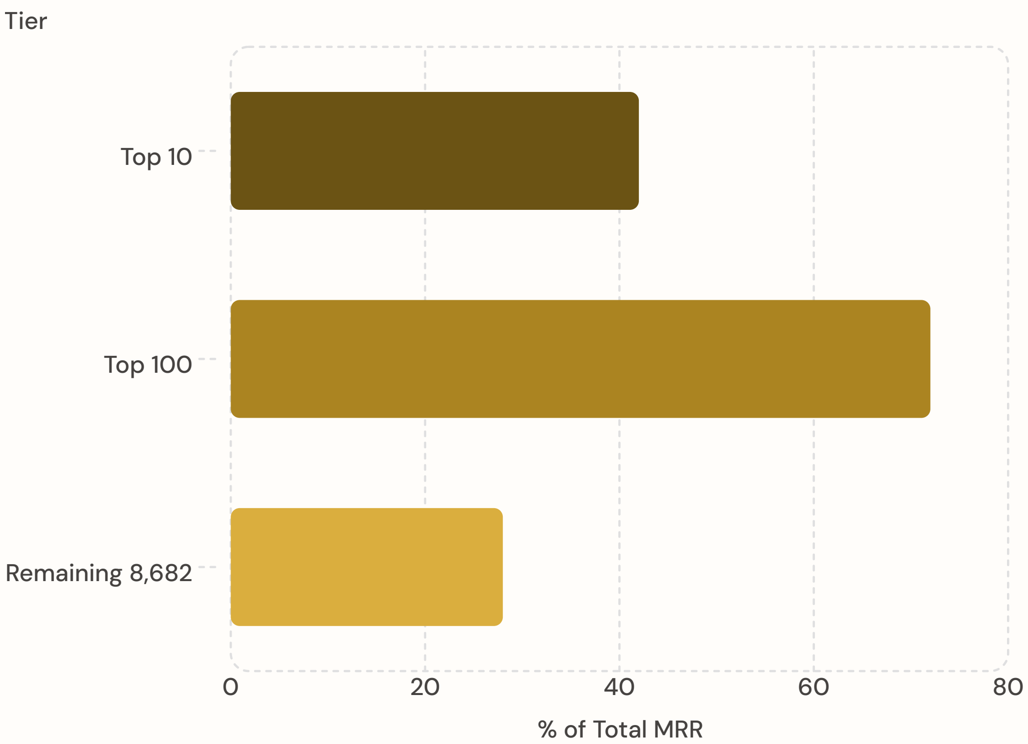
5,025 startups

sit at exactly zero MRR

42.8%

generate any recurring revenue

The Top 10 Own Nearly Half the Market



Revenue is brutally concentrated. A tiny elite captures the overwhelming majority of all recurring revenue in the marketplace.

Top 10 = 42% of all MRR

Top 100 = 72% of all MRR

Only 16 earn >$100K/month

Only 213 clear $10K/month

The rough threshold for a real business

Meet Stan, the Whale

One company dominates the entire marketplace — and the best assets like it never hit the market.

$3.57M MRR

Stan alone — roughly $28M/year

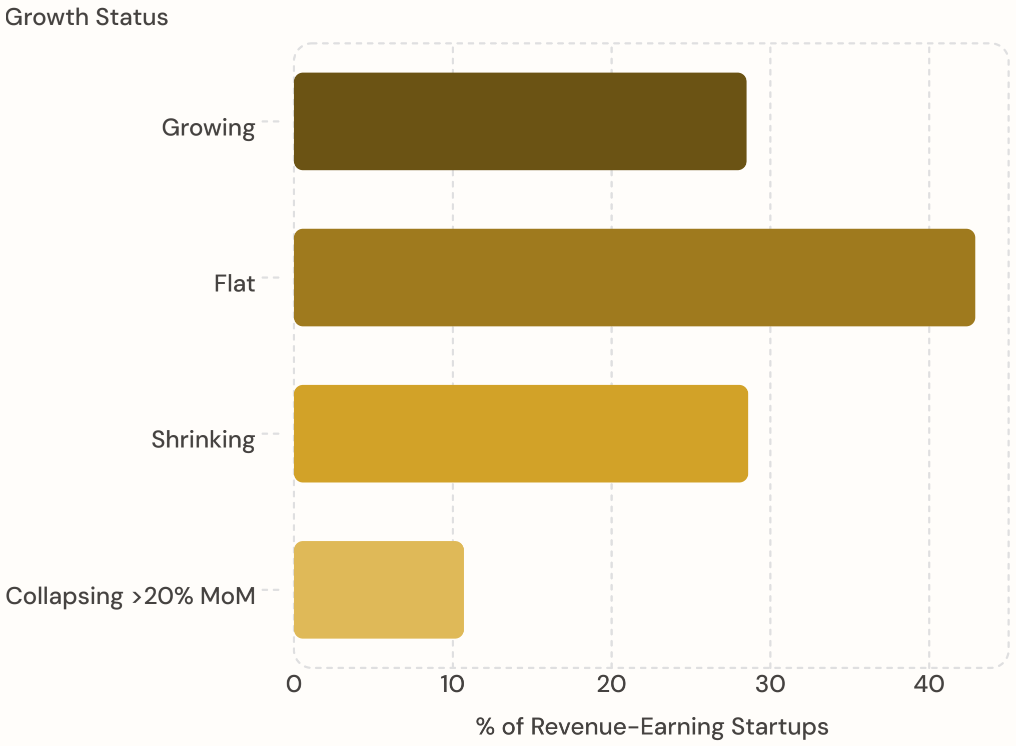
11.3% of All Revenue

One company's share of total annual marketplace revenue

Top 10 = 43.6%

Of all trailing-12-month revenue combined

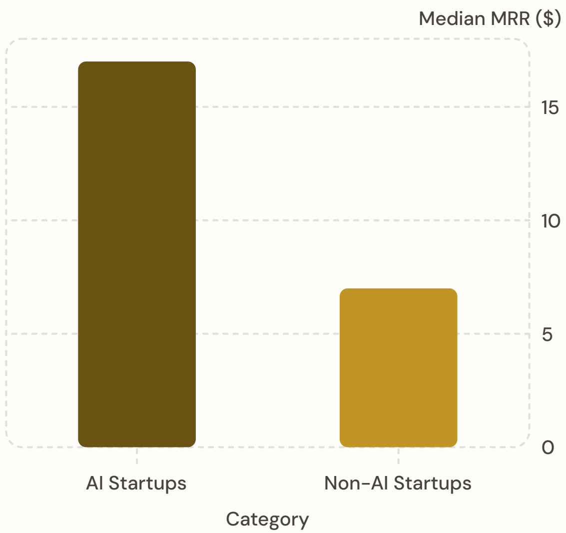
Making Money Is Not the Same as Growing



Among the 3,586 startups with revenue *and* growth data, reaching revenue is the easy part. Compounding is where almost everyone fails.

42.9% are completely flat — and 10.7% are collapsing at more than 20% month-over-month.

Everyone Is Building AI. Almost No One Is Monetizing It Better



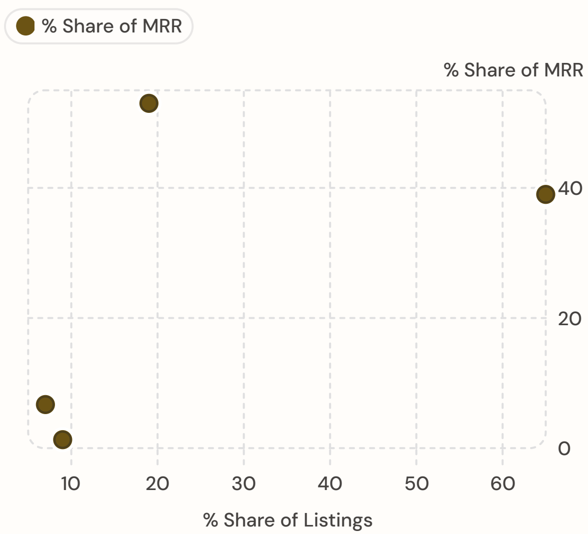
AI is the single largest category — 1,430 startups, 26% of everything categorized. The premium is basically noise.

AI multiplied the number of builders, not their unit economics. A crowded, undifferentiated gold rush where the picks-and-shovels players win.

Median AI MRR: $17

Median Non-AI MRR: $7

The US Earns. Everyone Else Builds.



Distribution and willingness-to-pay — not engineering talent — is the real moat. That gap is the opportunity.

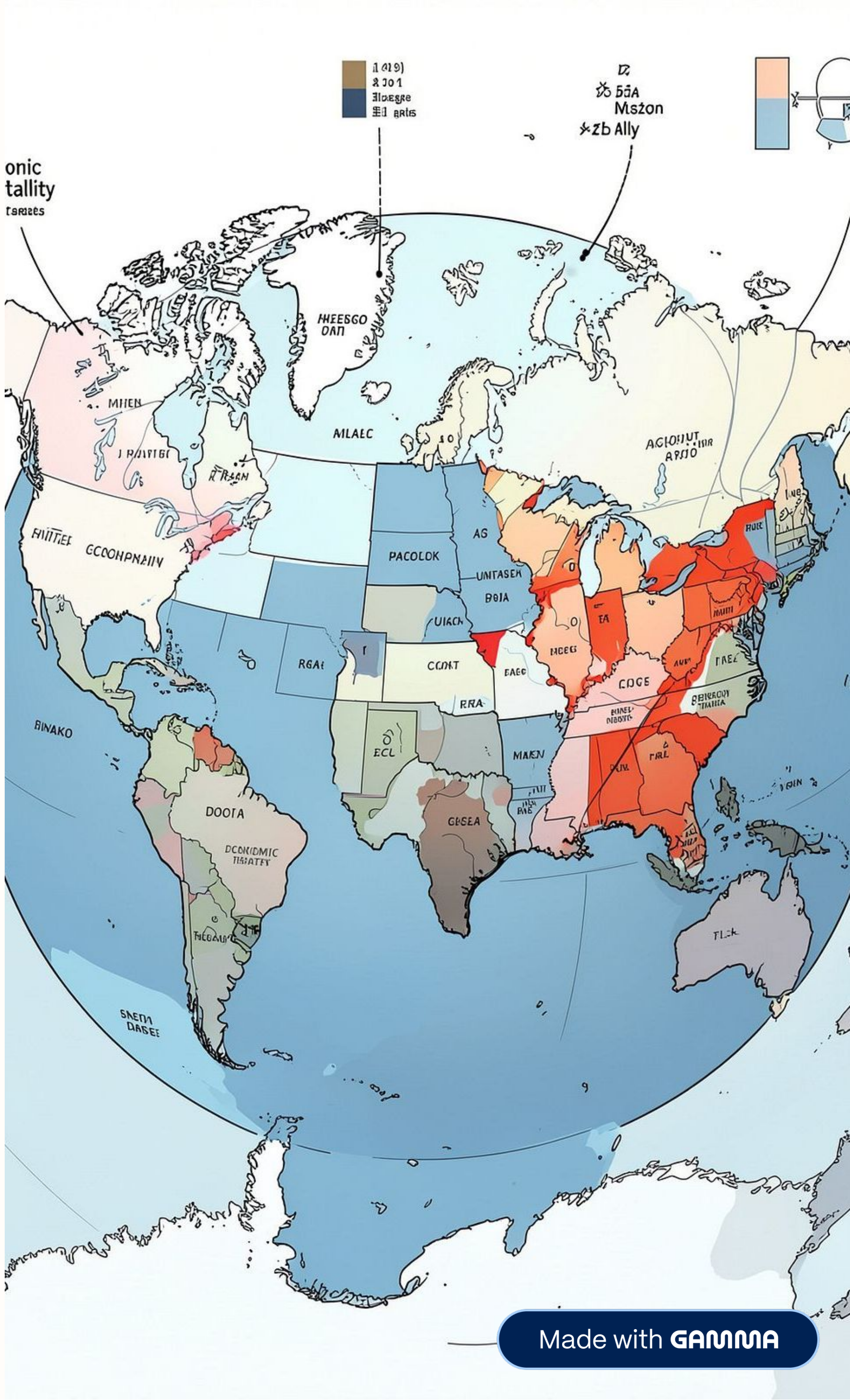
🇺🇸 US: 19% of listings, 53% of MRR

🇮🇳 India: 807 listings, only 1.3% of MRR

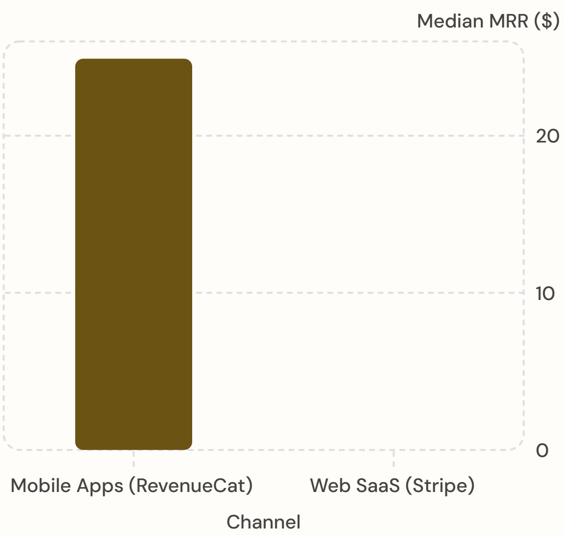
75% of Indian listings have zero revenue

🇫🇷 France: Quietly at parity

7% of listings, 6.7% of MRR



The Reliable Dollars Are in the App Store



Web SaaS holds all the whales — but the *typical* mobile app out-earns the *typical* web app by a wide margin.

Mobile = Higher Floor

Median $24.9 MRR. A grind, but reliable.

Web = Lottery Ticket

Median $0. Enormous winners, but rare.

1,952 Companies Are for Sale and They're Cheap

Nearly half of everything for sale has zero MRR. Buyers are purchasing code, domains, and audiences — not cash flow.

$137M

Total Asking Price

Across all 1,952 listings

$5K

Median Asking Price

Half of all listings priced below this

1.0x

Median Revenue Multiple

Essentially no premium for cash flow

49%

Zero MRR Listings

Selling code and domains, not revenue

> **Bottom line:** The indie SaaS market is a buyer's market — but most assets for sale aren't businesses. They're experiments.

Five Uncomfortable Truths & The Takeaway

1. **Software is a power law, not a ladder.**
   Building is democratized, outcomes are not.
2. **Revenue is a checkpoint, not a finish line.**
   Retention and growth separate businesses from projects.
3. **AI is a feature, not a moat, at the application layer.**
   It's multiplying builders, not necessarily unit economics.
4. **Distribution beats geography.**
   The build-monetize gap is where value leaks.
5. **The secondary market is immature and mispriced.**
   This is exactly when disciplined capital wins.

The takeaway depends on which seat you're in

Founders

Getting to revenue proves nothing. Underwrite your own retention before you celebrate.

Operators & Acquirers

The bargain bin rewards diligence. Buy growth the market failed to price.

Investors

Back distribution and durability, not the AI label.

> In a marketplace of 8,782 verified startups, the scarce resource was never the idea. It was the ability to keep the revenue.